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Second attacker triggers off bomb. No aid reaches Bhutto for over 10 minutes. She passes away in hospital at 6.16 p.m.

already heated political temperatures in Pakistan soaring. There was speculation over whether Musharraf would reimpose emergency he had lifted this month. For many, Bhutto's death is a clear message to the president. "We believe Musharraf should step down now... what is he waiting for?" said Qazi Hussain, chief of Jamaat-e-Islami which had already boycotted the polls. PPP spokesperson Farhatullah Babar said the party would demand postponement of elections to observe a traditional 40-day mourning. "We can't go for elections in such a situation," he said.

Following the news of her death, Pakistan's government went into overdrive to insist it had done all it could to keep the country's chief prime ministerial candidate secure. A harried-looking Musharraf named generic "terrorists" responsible, and announced three-day state mourning, sending Rangers pouring on to city streets. "This is nothing less than an

earthquake," commented a newscaster on Aaj TV, "We are all in a state of shock." The millions of tears that were shed had probably as much to do with the fear of what this tragedy means for Pakistan's future as with the loss of one of the country's most charismatic albeit controversial daughters.

Bhutto's return from exile was driven by the fading of Musharraf's authority and her determination to stake a claim to power. It meant that in the hour that she was the most vulnerable, Bhutto was also the most alone. At the time of her death her son Bilawal was at Oxford while her husband Asif Ali Zardari and her two daughters—Bakhtawar and Asifa—were at home in Dubai. Bhutto's ailing mother Nusrat, who suffers from dementia and lives with them, was not immediately informed of her death. Bhutto's funeral

AFP



IN A FIX: Musharraf (left) and army chief Kiani will have to shoulder the blame

in her village of Larkana in Sind will be all the more poignant as she will be buried in a grave next to her father.

For millions of Pakistanis the memories of the unnatural deaths of the charismatic but unfortunate members of the Bhutto clan—the Camelot of Pakistani politics—are still fresh: how Bhutto's father Zulfikar Ali was hanged by a military dictator in 1979 in what was later termed a "judicial murder", how her brother Shahnawaz was mysteriously poisoned in Cannes in 1985

and how her other brother Murtaza was shot dead in a controversial police encounter in Karachi during her own prime ministerial tenure in 1996. Despite personal setbacks and persistent rumours of corruption when in office, Bhutto was an indefatigable politician and a resolute believer in democracy for Pakistan.

Under Musharraf, as her country slipped over the boundary that divided the theological state from the hardline Islamist nation, Bhutto was always bound to be a moving target. A woman, an avowed liberal, and an advocate for a reduction in the role of the army in government, Bhutto's enemies comprised an entire powerful demographic of hardline clergy, Taliban elements in the country's polity and Islamist military men. Anyone, or all of them could have been part of the conspiracy to as-

sassinate Bhutto.

The day before she was killed Pakistani security agencies had put political parties on high alert with the warning that 'terrorists' might strike against leading politicians. The Bhutto killing came after three days of consecutive crippling bomb blasts, starting with the Id blast in Sherpao village in Pakistan's unruly north west where former minister Aftab Ahmed Khan Sherpao was the intended target.

Pakistan's turmoil could churn its